Twitter and the Politics of the Federal Deficit

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Abstract

American politicians have often been accused of changing their messaging around the federal deficit depending on their relative power status—advocating fiscal restraint (austerity) in opposition, while publicly supporting fiscal stimulus once in power. This paper examines this claim by tracking U.S. congressional members' deficit-related tweets between 2017–2023. Using a two-tier dictionary classification method, I identify tweets referencing the federal deficit and estimate how deficit-related messaging varies across institutional, legislative, and fiscal conditions using logistic regression. Deficit-tweeting is low overall (~0.7%) but varies significantly depending on a representative's party affiliation and power status: Republicans tweet about the deficit five times as often when in the minority, while Democrats' rates remain comparatively stable across majority/minority status. Republican leaders' deficit tweeting rates closely track those of rank-and-file members, while Democratic leadership shows more heterogeneous patterns. Notably, the fiscal size of legislation has no measurable effect on deficit tweeting rates. Results confirm that deficit rhetoric is largely a function of a member's relative political power and party affiliation—not underlying fiscal conditions—suggesting that elected officials use deficit messaging to advance partisan communication goals and legislative agendas.

1 Introduction

"It has become standard fare in American politics to watch each party rail against deficits when they are out of power but hungrily embrace deficits when in control and able to advance their own agenda." — **Kenneth Rogoff**, *Our Dollar, Your Problem*

1.1 Historical Background of Deficit Rhetoric

Debates over the size and scope of the federal deficit have been a central feature of American politics since its inception. Beginning as a constitutional question in the 1790s, deficits became increasingly normalized in the 20th century—largely due to the debt-financing of two world wars,[1] and gradual abandonment of the gold standard. By the late twentieth century, deficit discourse had turned uniquely partisan. Political leaders, including then President Ronald Reagan, attributed the country's economic woes—namely record high inflation—to the opposition parties' excessive spending policies. While Reagan advocated, and even campaigned on, reducing the federal government's size, his eight-year presidency saw a ~$1.7 trillion increase to the national debt.[2] Despite these unprecedented expansionary policies, Reagan was able to depict himself as a fiscal conservative—showing the potential power of using partisan rhetoric to shape public opinion. Reagan's successful rhetorical campaigns greatly influenced the coming decades of political communication, which has featured increasingly hostile messaging strategies adopted by both political parties.

Aside from the federal deficit's centrality in American political discourse, the federal deficit itself has implications for both the domestic and global economy. In the short run, deficit-spending is almost always stimulatory, often creating an incentive for the governing party to spend more to achieve higher growth. However, the debt that results from repeated deficits can exacerbate longer-term inflationary pressures, raise borrowing costs and crowd out private investment. This is not to suggest that deficits are inherently harmful or unnecessary, or that they have no place in effective economic policy—but rather that government spending carries meaningful impacts across a range of economic channels.

Nonetheless, despite both the rhetorical and economic significance of deficits—there exists little

[1] Under the gold standard, the government's ability to expand the money supply and finance deficits was constrained by the amount of gold reserves held by the central bank. The U.S. modified the gold standard twice (WWI and WWII) and ultimately removed it entirely in 1971 under President Nixon, removing this fiscal constraint entirely.

[2] Based on U.S. Department of the Treasury, *Debt to the Penny* dataset (1981–1989). Total debt outstanding rose from approximately $994 billion in January 1981 to $2.7 trillion in January 1989.

empirical analysis of when and why deficit rhetoric is used by elected officials. For instance, does political attention to the national deficit increase in response to rising debt levels—and is it correlated with other macroeconomic outcomes? Does an elected official's deficit rhetoric change in response to their power status or during legislative periods? This paper seeks to answer these questions. Using elected officials' tweets, I examine the evolution of deficit rhetoric and analyze how messaging varies across institutional contexts (who holds power), legislative periods, and macroeconomic conditions, providing the first large-scale empirical assessment of how deficit rhetoric functions within the incentive structure of American politics.

1.2 Motivation

Political discourse can influence public perceptions by directing attention to certain issues (e.g., health care, immigration) and influencing how citizens assign responsibility for policy outcomes (McCombs and Shaw 1972; Iyengar 1991). If this same mechanism applies to the national debt, then changes to public opinion on deficit spending may influence legislative agendas—giving political capital for party leaders to advance policy agendas. For instance, if online deficit rhetoric impacts public support for fiscal stimulus—then the majority party's legislative agenda may be forced to change, thereby impacting the economic trajectory of the country. Deficit rhetoric can also shape voters' beliefs about the fiscal responsibility of elected officials and the parties they represent. Thus, political entities that are more persuasive in their online messaging will potentially have greater success in electoral campaigns. If this is the case, elected officials would have reason to communicate about the deficit in such a way that maximizes success in elections and in passing or opposing legislation—whether it be consistent with their actual policies or not. By analyzing the rhetorical patterns of these officials, one can understand how political actors use the federal deficit to influence voters' beliefs, and shape public opinion.

1.3 Why Twitter?

Twitter (now X)[3] is a uniquely effective medium for this analysis. It is widely and consistently used by members of Congress and is a direct representation of each representative's rhetorical intentions. Moreover, tweets are standardized in format—meaning each post is timestamped, has the same character constraints, and are tied to verifiable individuals, allowing for large-scale and reproducible time-series analysis.

[3]Twitter became X in July 2023, following Elon Musk's acquisition. This paper uses "Twitter" as this study's data spans June 2017 to January 2023 (before the acquisition).

Most importantly, tweets reach a far greater audience than other traditional forms of communication (e.g., floor speeches, hearings) making them a more impactful communication medium for political messaging. Based on estimates of average follower count (with median accounts followed by roughly 100k users) and typical impression rates, even an average tweet can reach thousands of viewers, with more viral posts reaching hundreds of thousands (even millions) of people.

As a result, politicians are likely to be especially rhetorically conscious on Twitter given the platform's broad and immediate public exposure. In addition, tweets, unlike floor speeches or hearings (which vary in length and frequency) are published daily by almost all congressional members. This provides a comprehensive dataset (3.6M tweets), yielding greater statistical power and enabling stronger conclusions about key explanatory relationships.

2 Literature Review

A substantial body of literature has examined various aspects of U.S. federal deficit spending and the partisan nature of public finance more broadly (Alesina and Tabellini 1990; Pettersson-Lidbom 2001; Alesina and Passalacqua 2016). This research provides extensive insight into the determinants of fiscal outcomes, including how political institutions, electoral incentives, and partisan control over legislation influence government spending decisions.

While this research provides extensive analysis of actual fiscal outcomes, it offers little insight into the political communication surrounding the national debt itself. To my knowledge, this paper is the first comprehensive analysis of how politicians' deficit-related messaging varies with political contexts and fiscal circumstances.

3 Data

3.1 Congressional Twitter Dataset (2017–2023)

The dataset used for classifying tweets is Tweets of Congress (maintained by Alex Litel),[4] which contains all tweets (original, retweets, and quoted retweets) from the official accounts of U.S. congressional members between June 2017 and January 2023.[5] This automated pipeline ensures com-

[4]The data was generated via an open-source, serverless application that interfaces with the Twitter API, querying for new tweets at the top of each hour; each observation is stored as a JSON object with one file per day.

[5]Although more recent data (2024–2025) would provide greater relevance and utility—especially with the passage of the One Big Beautiful Bill (2025)—the cost of X's current API access, which changed following Elon Musk's

prehensive, continuous coverage of congressional Twitter activity during that period, with accounts updated through routine synchronization with legislator metadata. For instance, this system automatically adds newly sworn-in members to the metadata and removes non-members (i.e., those who lost an election, resigned, etc.)—thereby reflecting Congress's true composition at each point in time. Notably, I remove all accounts not directly tied to an individual congressional member, finalizing the dataset at roughly 3.6 million tweets.[6]

3.2 Dictionary-Based Classification of Deficit-Related Tweets

To identify deficit-related tweets, I implemented a two-tier keyword strategy in Python (pandas). The full code can be seen at the project's GitHub Repo.

Tier 1 – Anchor Keywords. Tweets were flagged as deficit-related if they contained unambiguous anchor phrases (e.g., *"national debt," "balanced budget," "fiscal responsibility"*). These strong keywords identify explicit deficit references with high confidence.

Tier 2 – Contextual Expansion. Tweets containing weaker terms (e.g., *"debt"*) were only flagged if they co-occurred with contextual phrases (e.g., *"federal," "budget," "tax," "spending"*).

The logic of my labeling framework is to balance the two key countervailing forces in text classification: precision and coverage. While a larger keyword dictionary would capture more subtle deficit references, it would also reduce precision by inflating the number of false positives. For instance, while including phrases like 'trillions of dollars' may capture references that would otherwise be missed, it also risks falsely tagging a growing number of unrelated tweets, such as discussions of income inequality or GDP growth. By contrast, a smaller dictionary would reduce false positives but would also diminish overall coverage, leading to more deficit-related tweets going unlabeled.

3.2.1 Illustrative Example

Figures 1 and 2 demonstrate the labeling logic. Rep. Alexandria Ocasio-Cortez's reference to "student loan debt" is not flagged: "debt" is a weak keyword but lacks an accompanying context term. By contrast, Speaker Kevin McCarthy's reference to the "national debt" matches a strong anchor

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acquisition, is beyond this project's financial resources. Under current pricing structures, replicating a dataset of similar size (roughly six million tweets) would cost between $30,000 and $42,000.

[6] Excluded accounts include party committee handles (e.g., @HouseDemocrats, @SenateGOP) and committee-specific accounts (e.g., Armed Services, Education). Only accounts directly tied to individual, serving members of Congress are retained.

keyword and is thus labeled as deficit-related.[7]

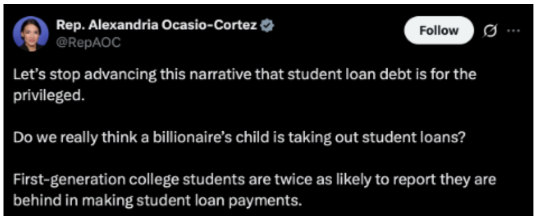

Figure 1: Rep. Alexandria Ocasio-Cortez

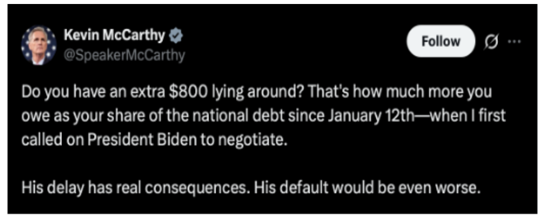

Figure 2: Rep. Kevin McCarthy

3.3 Measurement Error in Deficit Tweet Classification

While this classification provides simplicity and replicability, it also introduces potential sources of bias. These fall into two main categories:

(1) Dictionary Limits: Precision vs. Coverage

As noted, the challenge in using a dictionary-based method is balancing precision with coverage. In practice, I adjusted the specificity of both dictionaries iteratively based on the accuracy of their given outputs—which I assessed manually by checking the data. While bias in either direction is statistically possible, my strategy almost certainly underestimates total deficit rhetoric, since there are theoretically infinite ways to reference the federal debt.

(2) Variation in Rhetoric and Style

Bias may also arise from differences in rhetorical style across time, parties, and individuals. For instance, members who consistently use explicit terms like *"national debt"* are captured reliably, while those who reference deficits more vaguely or implicitly are systematically undercounted. If such variation correlates with party or institutional context (e.g., legislative periods), it could bias comparisons.

3.4 Extensions: Supervised Validation and Machine Learning Approaches

For future research considerations—whether involving similar or identical data—it is important to consider alternative, complementary approaches to improve labeling accuracy.

My current strategy relies on a rule-based dictionary method, where I defined Tier 1 and Tier 2 terms

[7] Speaker McCarthy's tweet was published outside the analytical timeframe (January 2023) but is included here solely as an illustrative example of the classification logic.

and applied them directly to the full dataset. While transparent, and easily adjustable, this approach inevitably misses implicit deficit references and requires subjective judgment in constructing the dictionaries.

A possible improvement would be to use a supervised dictionary validation approach. This method first requires manually labeling enough positive-class instances (i.e., deficit-related tweets), capturing both explicit and implicit references. Because deficit tweets are rare (~1–3% of all tweets), one would need to label roughly 20–30k tweets under an active learning strategy (or 100k+ under random sampling) to obtain 2–3k positive instances. This threshold aligns with best practices for addressing class imbalance (Japkowicz and Stephen 2002; He and Garcia 2009). After constructing this training data, one would build and test multiple dictionary configurations, each with varying levels of specificity, and then select the configuration with the highest validated accuracy.

Accuracy would be assessed with two measures:

(1) Coverage: the share of true deficit tweets correctly labeled.

(2) Precision: the false-positive rate.

Selecting the best model would thus require one to determine the ideal "accuracy" metric or determining the relative weight of coverage vs precision. This decision, like my dictionary choices, requires intuition and could be adjusted based on the researcher's preference.

In sum, a supervised dictionary validation approach would reduce under-detection of implicit references but would not fully eliminate the two forms of bias referenced in 3.2. For instance, expanding the dictionary to improve coverage risks a higher false-positive rate. The training dataset would capture fewer explicit tweets, and the best-performing dictionary would detect many of these indirect cases. Yet the same expansion may also misclassify unrelated tweets, raising the false-positive ratio. Thus, even if the most comprehensive model achieved the greatest overall accuracy, the fundamental bias would persist, albeit at a smaller scale.

3.5 Institutional, Legislative, and Economic Covariates

To contextualize congressional tweeting among broader political and economic phenomena, I integrated a wide set of temporal covariates into the dataset. Economic indicators—sourced from the U.S. Treasury and Federal Reserve—include ten-year interest rates, inflation (U.S. CPI YoY) and multiple measures of federal debt (publicly held debt, intragovernmental holdings, and total debt outstanding).

Institutional context is captured through variables on presidential party, House and Senate control, majority and minority leadership, and whether government is unified or divided, as well as monthly congressional approval ratings.

Legislative periods are represented by data on major bills from 2017 to 2023 (e.g., CARES Act, PPP, CHIPS Act, IRA). Periods are defined by one month before and after passage. For instance, the Tax Cuts and Jobs Act was signed into law by President Trump in December 2017, making its designated legislative period November 2017–January 2018. Fiscal impact estimates for each bill come from the Congressional Budget Office (CBO) and are normalized when included in regression specifications.[8]

Finally, my research constructs a novel partisanship score formula to capture the level of partisan division in each legislative period. The measure is defined as the absolute difference between Democratic and Republican support rates for a given bill:

$$\text{Partisanship Score} = \left| \frac{\text{Dem Yea}}{\text{Dem Total}} - \frac{\text{Rep Yea}}{\text{Rep Total}} \right|$$

This score ranges from 0 (perfect bipartisan support) to 1 (completely partisan support, with only one party voting in favor). For regression analysis, I normalize the score to standardize across legislative periods.

4 Methodology

4.1 Logistic Regression Framework for Deficit Tweeting

My research objective is to examine how deficit rhetoric varies with political, fiscal, and legislative contexts. To assess this relationship, I estimate a logistic regression model where the dependent variable is the proportion of a member's tweets in a given month that are deficit-related.[9] This allows me to estimate how the likelihood of deficit-related tweeting changes across political parties, institutional conditions, and legislative environments.

The unit of analysis is the member-month. For each member i in month t, let p_{it} denote the prob-

[8]The fiscal impact of each policy bill is its 10-year CBO estimate: how much the policy bill is expected to contribute to the federal deficit in the ten years following its implementation.

[9]Considering the outcome variable is a share bounded between (0,1), a traditional linear regression model (which allows for values to be negative or greater than 1) would not be appropriate. Logistic regression constrains predictions to valid probabilities and allows coefficients to be interpreted in terms of changes in relative odds of deficit tweeting.

ability that a given tweet is deficit-related. The explanatory vector X_{it} includes party affiliation, legislative timing indicators, institutional control variables, and their interactions, as well as normalized measures of bill partisanship and fiscal magnitude. Models include member fixed effects (α_i) and month fixed effects (γ_t), with standard errors two-way clustered by member and month. Formally,

$$\log\left(\frac{p_{it}}{1-p_{it}}\right) = \alpha_i + \gamma_t + \beta X_{it}$$

Coefficients are exponentiated and reported as odds ratios. Because the dependent variable is constructed from aggregated tweet counts, estimates can be interpreted as the effect of these factors on the underlying probability that a tweet is deficit-related.

4.1.1 Member and Time Fixed Effects

Member fixed effects absorb differences across legislators and between parties. For example, Senator Rand Paul tweets far more often than Senator Ted Cruz, and Republicans, generally speaking, tweet more about deficits than Democrats. These baseline differences are captured by α_i, so estimates rely on within-member changes over time. Moreover, month fixed effects absorb shocks common to all legislators in a given month. For instance, during COVID-19 legislative periods (i.e., CARES Act), both parties reduced deficit rhetoric at similar rates. Month fixed effects, γ_t, ensures that these shared shocks, such as COVID-19, are not misattributed to partisan–institutional dynamics.

4.1.2 Interpreting Odds Ratios and Interaction Effects

Each coefficient represents how the odds of tweeting about the deficit change relative to some baseline condition—which is defined as Democrats holding the presidency outside of a legislative window (i.e., when no major legislation is being voted on). The coefficient on GOP then captures the baseline ratio of odds between Democrats and Republicans. Interaction terms assess whether this baseline ratio of odds (coefficient on GOP) changes as the political context moves from the baseline circumstance to another political context. Put differently, the interaction terms examine whether Republicans respond (tweet) differently than Democrats when the underlying political environment changes—for example, when moving into a legislative period or when control of government shifts. If the ratio of odds stays the same when moving into another political circumstance—i.e., Republicans and Democrats change their tweeting rates at similar rates—then the interaction terms will be insignificant.

4.1.3 Illustration of Interaction Effects in Legislative Contexts

For example, consider how a single member's behavior changes over time. Suppose a Democratic member increases their probability of tweeting about the deficit when moving from a non-legislative period to a legislative window. The interaction terms in the model ask whether Republican members change their behavior more or less than Democrats under the same shift. For example, if the interaction term GOP × Legislative Window has an odds ratio less than 1, this indicates that Republicans change their deficit-related tweeting less than Democrats during legislative periods, relative to the baseline condition.

Figure 3 provides a visual illustration of how the GOP coefficient defines the baseline Republican–Democrat odds ratio and how the interaction term modifies that ratio when the political context changes.

Baseline Condition	**New Political Context**	**Interaction Odds Ratio**
GOP OR = $\frac{\text{Odds}_{RB}}{\text{Odds}_{DB}}$	GOP OR = $\frac{\text{Odds}_{RL}}{\text{Odds}_{DL}}$	Interaction OR = $\frac{\text{Odds}_{RL} / \text{Odds}_{DL}}{\text{Odds}_{RB} / \text{Odds}_{DB}}$
baseline Republican–Democrat odds ratio	*Republican–Democrat odds ratio in new context*	*how the partisan odds ratio changes from baseline*

Figure 3: Interpreting the GOP Coefficient and Interaction Effects.

An odds ratio greater than 1 indicates that Republicans increase their deficit-related tweeting more than Democrats under that condition, relative to the baseline, while an odds ratio less than 1 indicates that the Republican–Democrat difference contracts.

4.2 Sequential Model Specifications and Identification Strategy

My research goal is to understand how deficit rhetoric—specifically among Democrats and Republicans—changes with varying institutional, fiscal and legislative conditions. To do this, I estimate a sequence of specifications that control for these variables in a progressively specific manner. The baseline model (Regression 1) interacts party affiliation with legislative windows. Furthermore, it includes coefficients to describe how this baseline tweeting gap changes with differing levels of bill partisanship and fiscal impact (CBO estimate of the bill). Such coefficients help illuminate the relationship—or lack thereof—between the divisiveness of a bill, or its fiscal impact, and how members talk about it on Twitter.

The second model (Regression 2) adds a further control by conditioning on the presidential party (i.e., which party holds the presidency). The change in coefficient estimates between Regression 2 and the preceding model indicates that conditioning on presidential power is an important consideration when analyzing deficit rhetoric. In other words, tweeting gaps among parties are a function of whose party holds executive power. Without including this condition, one would improperly interpret the significance of tweeting differences. Finally, the last specification (Regression 3) adds further detail by controlling for the composition of the legislative branch (Congress).

5 Results

5.1 Time-Series Trends in Deficit Tweeting (2017–2023)

Figure 4 shows the monthly share of congressional deficit tweets, by party, from June 2017 to January 2023. Shaded areas indicate legislative periods – defined as the month before, during, and after the passage of a fiscally significant bill. Blue shaded areas represent legislative periods under a Democratic President (Biden) and red shaded areas show legislative periods under a Republican President (Trump).[10]

The baseline deficit tweeting share for both parties is low, generally under 1% when averaged across members over six years, with notable accelerations occurring around legislative periods. Democratic tweeting patterns remain relatively consistent across the six years, with three notable peaks, all during legislative periods: December 2017 (Tax Cuts and Jobs Act), October 2021 (Infrastructure Investment and Jobs Act), and August 2022 (Inflation Reduction Act, CHIPS & Science Act). Republicans, however, demonstrate consistently higher deficit tweeting rates as the minority party, as illustrated in the peaks (2022, 2023) compared to relatively low rates from 2017–2021.

[10] Legislative periods exclude small appropriations, procedural votes, and commemorations.

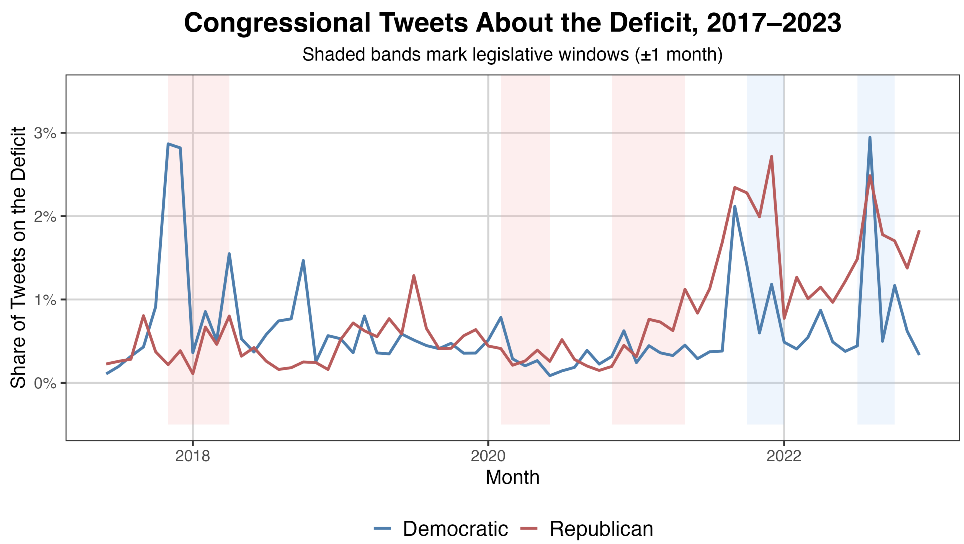

Figure 4: Share of congressional tweets about the deficit.

5.2 Deficit Tweeting and Macroeconomic Conditions

Figure 5, which plots deficit tweet share against US CPI inflation (YoY), reveals a relatively strong positive relationship, as indicated by its large r = .78. There are a few plausible explanations for this linear relationship. First, the elevated inflation rates of 2022, peaking at 9.1% in June (40-year high), may have increased elected officials' concern about deficit spending. Public discontent over higher prices may have also pressured representatives to take a more hawkish approach on federal expenditures.

Another explanation could be that along with higher inflation, the significant, and contentious, fiscal legislation being proposed in the summer of 2022 (e.g., IRA, CHIPS) may have drawn concerns from representatives, prompting more congressional tweets on the topic.

5.3 Distribution of Deficit Tweeting Across Members and Parties

Figure 6 presents member-level distributions of deficit tweeting, calculated as the share of each member's tweets that mention the deficit over the entire period. As illustrated by the dashed lines (party means), Republicans tweet about the deficit more frequently than Democrats, with average shares of 0.81% and 0.62%, respectively.

Democrats display a relatively compact distribution, with most representatives falling below 0.7%. Republicans, however, show far greater variability within their party. The GOP's right tail distribu-

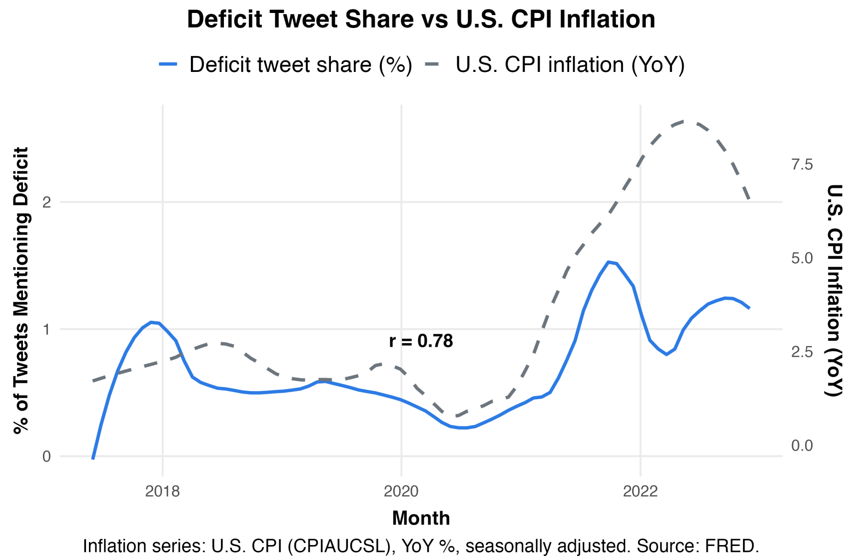

Figure 5: Deficit tweet share vs. U.S. CPI inflation.

tion illustrates that, compared to their Democratic colleagues, a far greater proportion of members tweet about the deficit at much higher rates, with outliers reaching 4–8%.

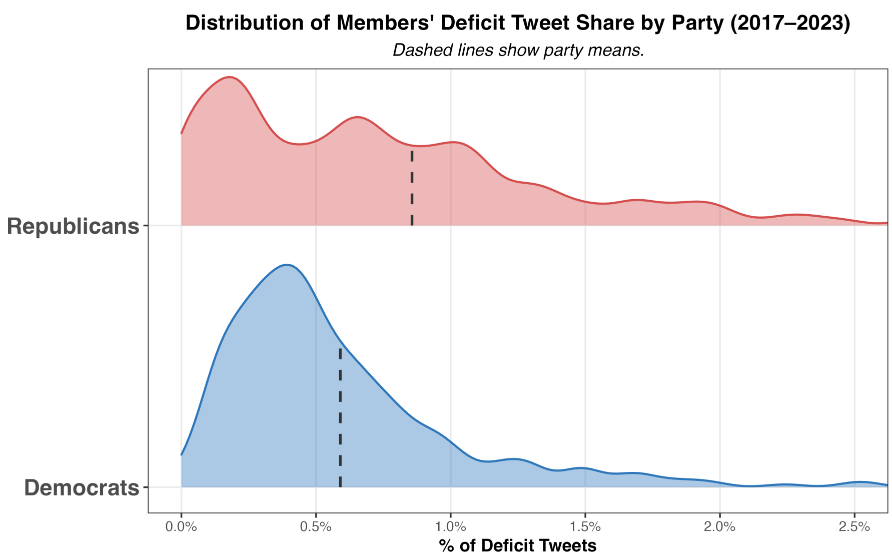

Figure 6: Share of deficit tweets by party (member-level distribution). Dashed lines show party means.

Figure 7 breaks down these distributions further by institutional power status (majority vs. minority). The left and right panels compare the distribution when a member's party controls the presidency (in-power) versus when it does not (out-of-power). For instance, Democrats would be considered in-power from January 2021 to January 2023 under President Joe Biden, while Republicans would be out-of-power during this same period.

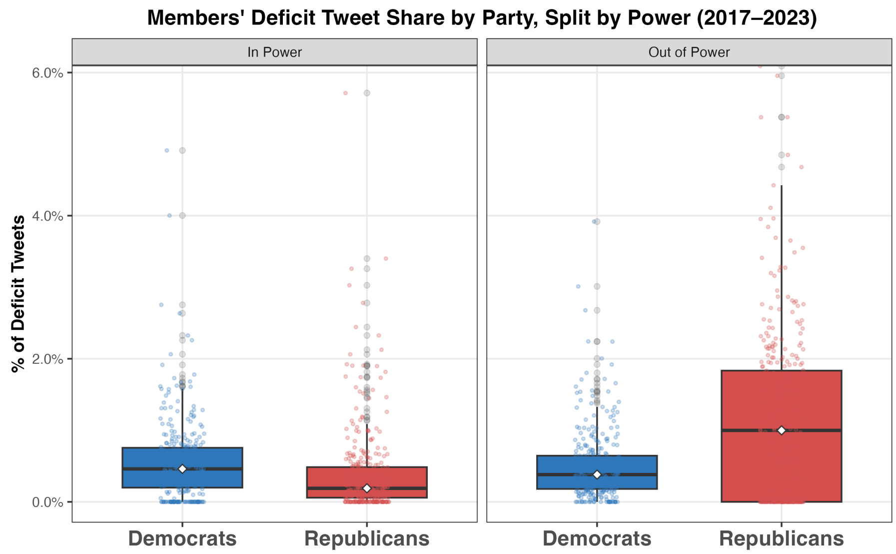

Figure 7: Distribution of deficit tweets by power (boxplot).

Figure 7 shows a clear asymmetry in Republican tweeting patterns between these periods. When moving between power contexts, the Republican median tweet share increases five-fold, from 0.2% to 1.0%, and the interquartile range widens from 0.6% to 1.8%. Put simply, Republicans were far more likely to tweet about the deficit under President Biden than under President Trump. This contrast illustrates a cohesive shift among Republicans to emphasize the deficit more when they lack legislative influence. Democrats, by contrast, remain relatively stable across contexts and in fact demonstrate a modest increase in spread and averages when in power.

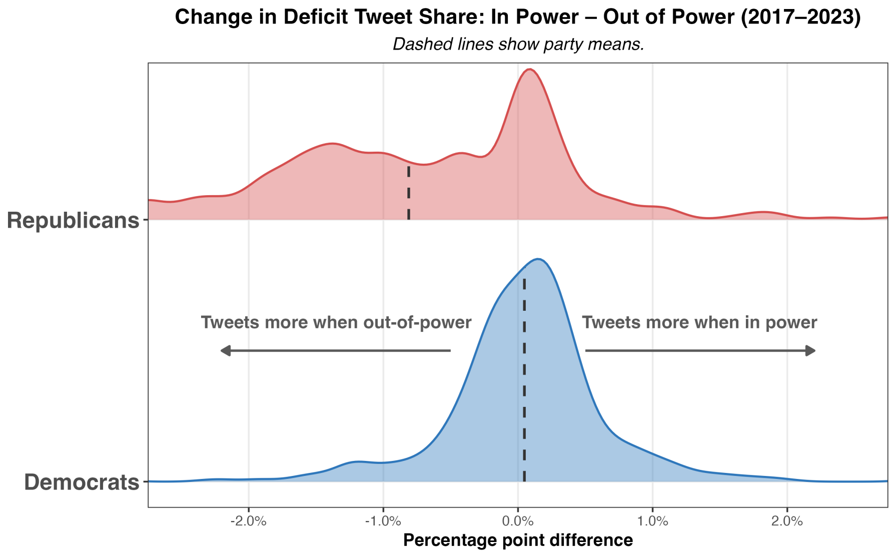

Figure 8: In–out shifts in deficit tweeting (histogram). Dashed lines show party means.

Figure 8 visualizes these shifts more directly by plotting the distribution of changes in deficit tweeting when moving from in-power to out-of-power contexts. The x-axis represents the difference in deficit tweet share between these two periods for each member (in minus out). Positive values indicate that a member tweeted more about the deficit when in power, while negative values indicate higher tweeting rates when out of power. The GOP's comprehensive party shift is evident, with the bulk of the party's distribution skewed negative (i.e., most GOP members tweet more when in the opposition).

5.4 Deficit Rhetoric Among Congressional Leadership

Table 1 summarizes deficit-tweeting by House and Senate leaders across majority/minority contexts. Patterns differ by party and chamber, with the sharpest contrasts in the Senate: Senator Chuck Schumer tweeted about deficits far more as Majority Leader (4.0%) than as Minority Leader (1.0%), while Senator Mitch McConnell did the reverse (1.9% in the minority vs. 0.05% in the majority). In the House, Representative Pelosi tweeted about deficits more in the minority (1.1%) than as Speaker (0.5%).

Table 1: Deficit tweeting by congressional leaders (House and Senate; majority vs. minority roles).

Deficit Tweeting Rates by Congressional Leaders (2017–2023)

Includes only leaders who served during this period

Leadership Role	Party	Total Tweets	Debt Tweets	% Deficit-Related
Chuck Schumer				
Senate Majority Leader	Democratic	4173	167	4.00
Senate Minority Leader	Democratic	8994	93	1.03
Kevin McCarthy				
House Minority Leader	Republican	762	0	0.00
Mitch McConnell				
Senate Majority Leader	Republican	5622	3	0.05
Senate Minority Leader	Republican	2483	47	1.89
Nancy Pelosi				
House Majority Leader	Democratic	5617	28	0.50
House Minority Leader	Democratic	2705	30	1.11
Paul Ryan				
House Majority Leader	Republican	3570	6	0.17

Notably, Representative McCarthy has relatively few tweets (762). Because leaders often switch or add handles when roles change, the data collection process may have failed to include relevant accounts. Thus, McCarthy's deficit tweet share should be interpreted cautiously.

While the preceding analysis covers broader party-level trends, exploring individual leaders' tweeting patterns provides insight into how key political figures communicate about the deficit in varying institutional contexts. Considering the legislative and electoral significance of these figures, their messaging strategies are more influential and calculated than those of rank-and-file members. For instance, party leaders may use specific communication strategies around legislative periods to catalyze or bar the passage of key bills. Examining these trends can therefore help illustrate the degree of strategic communication employed by top legislators, and by extension — the party they represent.

Consider the differences in tweeting patterns among the two parties' top legislators. First, for Democrats, the divergent tweeting patterns of Speaker Pelosi and Senator Schumer suggest a weak intra-party alignment in messaging. These patterns are consistent with the broader Democratic caucus, which shows no discernible difference in deficit tweeting between power contexts (as shown in Figure 7 and Figure 8). The Republican party, however, is more responsive to changes in their power status. Senator McConnell's increase in deficit tweeting in out-of-power contexts mirrors the broader Republican trend illustrated in Figure 8. Furthermore, McConnell's tweeting patterns confirm long-held conceptions about his communication and political style, which emphasizes unrelenting opposition to Democratic fiscal policies (MacGillis 2014; Hacker and Pierson 2016).

5.5 Deficit Tweeting Within Legislative Windows

Table 2: Deficit share within legislative windows, by party.

Deficit Share Within Each Window by Party (Tweet Level)

Conditional share of deficit tweets given the tweet is inside the window.

		Tweets (N)	Deficit (N)	Deficit Rate (%)
All Tweets (Baseline)	Democratic	2,138,163	13,199	0.6%
	Republican	1,467,248	11,903	0.8%
Any Legislative Window	Democratic	687,875	5,569	0.8%
	Republican	486,104	4,558	0.9%
IRA / CHIPS Window	Democratic	91,767	1,194	1.3%
	Republican	74,031	1,421	1.9%
CARES Window	Democratic	131,549	521	0.4%
	Republican	82,587	231	0.3%
PPP–HCE Window	Democratic	135,059	342	0.3%
	Republican	88,440	250	0.3%
COVID Window (CARES or PPP–HCE)	Democratic	171,383	627	0.4%
	Republican	109,109	335	0.3%
TCJA Window	Democratic	85,463	1,680	2.0%
	Republican	62,372	139	0.2%

*Percentages are conditional on being inside each window; counts are tweet totals **within** the window.*

Table 2 reports the conditional share of tweets mentioning the deficit within ±1-month windows around major bills, split by party (with a pooled/overall column for reference). At baseline, Republicans tweet about the deficit more often (0.8%) than Democrats (0.6%) – a gap that persists across most legislative windows. During the Inflation Reduction Act (2022) and CHIPS Act (2022) periods, Republicans' tweets accelerated, with deficit mentions at nearly 2.0%, compared to 1.3% among Democrats. However, the TCJA (2017)—a partisan GOP tax cut—is a noticeable and stark exception. During these three months, the Democrats' deficit share spikes to 2.0%, while the Republicans' share falls to just 0.2%, reflecting a partisan realignment around a highly divisive bill. In contrast, during the COVID relief period in 2020 – a non-partisan voting context – both parties converged at very low levels (0.3–0.4%).

5.6 Regression Results: Institutional and Legislative Interactions

The following regression models offer a structured approach to examining how institutional, fiscal, and partisan contexts affect the likelihood of congressional deficit tweeting. Each model includes interaction coefficients of the general form GOP × Conditioning Variable, indicating whether the baseline Republican–Democratic difference changes under specific conditions.

Table 3: Regression 1: Legislative windows.

Legislative Windows and Major Bills

	Odds Ratio	95% CI
GOP × Legislative window	0.88	[0.57, 1.36]
GOP × COVID window	0.65	[0.33, 1.28]
GOP × IRA/CHIPS window	1.24	[0.46, 3.32]
GOP × Bill partisanship (z)	0.82	[0.52, 1.29]
GOP × Fiscal magnitude (z)	1.02	[0.97, 1.07]

*Odds ratios with 95% CIs; *** p<0.001, ** p<0.01, * p<0.05.*

The baseline model, Table 3, examines partisan differences in legislative periods without conditioning on institutional control. The non-significant results suggest that, when averaged across both Democratic and Republican presidencies, legislative windows themselves do not systematically impact the partisan gap in deficit tweeting.

Table 4: Regression 2: Majority context (presidency).

Presidential Control and Legislative Windows

	Odds Ratio	95% CI
GOP × Legislative window	0.38***	[0.26, 0.56]
GOP × Minority presidency	1.87*	[1.07, 3.27]
GOP × Legislative window × Minority presidency	4.24***	[2.27, 7.92]
GOP × COVID window	1.03	[0.61, 1.74]
GOP × IRA/CHIPS window	0.78	[0.33, 1.85]
GOP × Bill partisanship (z)	0.51***	[0.41, 0.63]
GOP × Fiscal magnitude (z)	0.99	[0.97, 1.01]

*Odds ratios with 95% CIs; *** p<0.001, ** p<0.01, * p<0.05.*

Table 4 controls for presidential party by adding an indicator for serving under the out-party president (GOP under a Democratic president; Democrats under a Republican president) and by interacting it with Legislative window, plus the three-way term GOP × Legislative window × Minority presidency. These terms let the GOP–Dem deficit-tweeting gap differ under Democratic vs. Republican presidents and specifically during legislative months.

Republicans' odds of tweeting about deficits are nearly double (OR = 1.87) when not holding the presidency (i.e., Joe Biden is President) compared to Democrats under the same condition. In contrast, GOP × Legislative window (OR= 0.38) highlights that under a Republican presidency, the partisan gap narrows during legislative months—the odds of the GOP tweeting are 62% lower than those of Democrats. In other words, Republicans are far less likely to discuss the deficit when their party holds the executive branch. This pattern aligns with Figure 4, which shows that Republican tweeting contracts while Democratic tweeting spikes as Congress passed the Tax Cuts and Jobs Act in late 2017. However, the three-way interaction coefficient GOP × Legislative window × Minority presidency reveals a reversal of this trend (OR= 4.24). Under a Democratic presidency (Joe Biden), Republicans' odds of tweeting are more than four times higher than those of Democrats in the same condition.

Table 5: Regression 3: Majority context — chamber and presidency combinations.

Government Control and Legislative Windows

	Odds Ratio	95% CI
GOP × Legislative window (GOP trifecta)	0.31***	[0.21, 0.46]
GOP × Legislative window × Dem trifecta	7.00***	[4.13, 11.85]
GOP × Legislative window × GOP Senate+Presidency	0.85	[0.47, 1.54]
GOP × COVID window	1.10	[0.62, 1.95]
GOP × IRA/CHIPS window	0.79	[0.33, 1.86]
GOP × Bill partisanship (z)	0.50***	[0.39, 0.64]
GOP × Fiscal magnitude (z)	0.99	[0.97, 1.01]

*Odds ratios with 95% CIs; *** p<0.001, ** p<0.01, * p<0.05.*

Table 5 examines how the tweeting gap changes by who controls congressional and executive branches. A GOP trifecta means Republicans held the presidency, House, and Senate simultaneously—a condition they held from 2017 to 2019. The model includes indicators for these control combinations: the baseline is Democrats outside legislative windows when their party controls no institution (minority in both chambers and not holding the presidency). This context would describe Democrats, between 2017 and 2019, in non-legislative periods (i.e., not during Tax Cuts and Jobs Act).

GOP × Legislative window (OR = 0.31) indicates that during legislative months, when holding a trifecta, Republicans' odds of tweeting are 69% lower than Democrats. The Tax Cuts and Jobs Act

(2017)—a legislative window under a GOP trifecta—is an illustration of this condition. However, once conditioning on a Democratic trifecta, this effect reverses. Relative to the baseline condition (a GOP trifecta), Republicans' odds of deficit tweeting are seven times higher than those of Democrats in the same context. The juxtaposition of these two coefficients (OR = 0.31) versus (OR = 7.00) illustrates that legislative timing by itself is not a determinant of tweeting gaps—but who governs is. Under Democratic control (i.e., 2021–2023), Republicans accelerate deficit rhetoric during legislative months, while under the GOP trifecta (i.e., 2017–2019), they significantly reduce deficit tweeting frequencies.

5.6.1 *Effects of Bill Partisanship and Fiscal Magnitude*

Across all three specifications, the coefficients for Fiscal magnitude (z) are statistically insignificant (~1.0). These coefficients, based on a normalized measure of a given bill's 10-year CBO estimate, suggest that the fiscal consequences of policy do not systematically impact partisan tweeting gaps.

Bill partisanship (z), however, shows significant contractions in the GOP-Dem tweeting gap once institutional control is included (OR ~ 0.50). In other words, for each one-SD increase in a bill's partisanship score, the GOP-Dem gap contracts by roughly half. Notably, because these variables are continuous (i.e., z-scores), the coefficients represent slopes rather than a baseline-specific effect. For example, in the context of bill partisanship, if Republicans are twice as likely as Democrats to tweet at z = 0 (OR = 2.0), that gap narrows to parity at z = 1 (OR = 1.0).

6 Discussion

6.1 Summary of Empirical Patterns in Deficit Tweeting

My research finds that deficit rhetoric on Twitter among U.S. congressional members is low—fluctuating between averages of .5% to 2% throughout the six-year periods (or 5-20 "deficit tweets" per 1000 tweets). However, my results highlight significant and important nuances. Specifically, I find that variation in deficit tweeting is strongly tied to two factors—relative institutional power and legislative timing. I also find that deficit rhetoric is not tied to the fiscal magnitude of policy bills; that is, tweeting rates are uncorrelated with the long-term fiscal impact of legislation (measured by its 10-year CBO estimate).

As noted, institutional power—whether a member's party holds congressional and/or executive control—is a key determinant of deficit tweeting among Republicans, but not Democrats. It also helps to explain significant variations in tweeting gaps among the parties. For instance, Republicans' deficit rhetoric increases five-fold when transitioning into out-of-power contexts (holding all other factors constant) while Democrats' rates remain constant throughout. Republican leaders mirror the trends of their rank-and-file members (by increasing deficit tweeting in out-of-power contexts), while Democratic leaders show no discernible pattern in contextual tweeting among each other.

Regression analysis also indicates that legislative windows influence deficit tweeting only after conditioning on presidential and/or congressional control. In other words, Republican–Democrat tweeting differences only change once one considers who is in power. The partisan tweeting gap contracts in legislative months where Democrats hold the presidency.

These results suggest that, for Republicans, deficit rhetoric functions as a context-dependent communication resource. Members will emphasize the deficit when political accountability is externalized—that is, when Democrats hold power. However, once Republicans move into periods of legislative power (i.e., political accountability is internalized), they tend to diminish their deficit rhetoric significantly.

6.2 Deficit Rhetoric is Independent of Fiscal Conditions

Results show no discernible relationship between the fiscal magnitude of legislation and deficit tweeting: members do not increase references to the deficit in legislative periods that are characterized by large spending. For example, deficit tweeting is the same for policy bills that have a low fiscal impact (such as the Inflation Reduction Act) and legislation with high fiscal impact (such as the Tax Cuts and Jobs Act). Notably, the fiscal magnitude of bills does not predict tweeting gaps once institutional controls are included.

One would assume that deficit rhetoric should derive from the very thing it references—the federal deficit. My research, however, suggests that no such relationship exists. This is an important relationship, or lack thereof, that stakeholders (voters, journalists, and forecasters) should understand: deficit rhetoric, most of the time, should not be interpreted as a direct proxy for fiscal concern, but rather as a reflection of a representative's power and political incentives.

6.3 Partisan Asymmetry and Message Coordination

Beyond these aggregate patterns, my findings highlight important asymmetries between political parties' communication patterns. First, Republicans exhibit greater sensitivity to power status; that is, their deficit tweeting rates fluctuate significantly depending on who controls Congress and the presidency.

The second asymmetry which warrants consideration, is the difference in coordination and alignment among party leaders and rank-and-file members. Republican leaders, compared to their Democratic counterparts, demonstrate a greater degree of both partisan messaging and uniformity with their members. For instance, consider Representative Paul Ryan—a self-described fiscal conservative, Speaker of the House from 2017–2019, and a central political figure in modern discourse surrounding the national deficit. While Ryan frequently branded himself a "deficit hawk," his public deficit messaging was minimal during unified GOP control as Congress advanced the Tax Cuts and Jobs Act, which the CBO estimated would add roughly $1.5 trillion to the debt over ten years. In short, Ryan rarely emphasized the deficit while orchestrating a major deficit-increasing legislative agenda. Ryan's self-contradictory tweeting behavior is emblematic of the claim I have highlighted in this section: deficit messaging, especially for Republicans, is not a proxy for genuine fiscal worries, but is a reflection of a representative's political incentives.

Furthermore, as the only Republican to serve as both the minority and majority leader, Mitch McConnell serves as an effective illustration of a representative cyclically aligning their rhetoric to serve political means. As Table 1 shows, during his four-year role as majority leader, McConnell tweeted about the deficit just three times out of 5,622 total tweets—a staggering 0.05% deficit-tweet rate. This stands in sharp contrast to his tweeting patterns as the minority leader, under President Joe Biden, where McConnell's deficit tweeting rates increased to 1.89%—a 38-fold increase. Senator McConnell—the spokesperson for the Republican party—made a conscious effort to vastly alter his deficit-rhetoric during his time in the opposition. And the broader Republican party followed in unison with his messaging goal—increasing deficit tweeting rates significantly in minority contexts. Taken together, these rhetorical trends suggest a top-down messaging dynamic among Republicans: party leaders establish rhetorical cues that are consequently adopted by rank-and-file members.

By comparison, the Democratic party illustrates both less intra-party coordination and less sensitivity to changes in their relative power. For example, the diverging tweeting patterns of Speaker Pelosi and Senator Schumer suggest a comparatively weaker intra-party alignment in messaging. Speaker Pelosi tweets at higher rates in the minority versus majority (1.11% vs. 0.50%), while Senator Schumer tweets at significantly higher rates in the majority (1.03% vs. 4.00%). My results suggest that Democratic messaging is far more heterogeneous at both the leadership level (Pelosi and Schumer), and among rank-and-file members themselves. Overall, Republicans—intentional or not—are far more successful in articulating organized and context-specific messaging.

6.4 The Political Incentives of the Federal Deficit: Blame Avoidance and Ideological Signaling

The bulk of this paper thus far has dealt with objectively describing the nature of deficit rhetoric among U.S. congressional members. My analysis naturally brings about a key question: what motivates politicians' deficit-related messaging on Twitter? While the precise motivations underlying elected officials' communication choices cannot be directly observed—i.e., one cannot know the reasoning behind every tweet—the systematic patterns in the data provide a constructive foundation for interpretive analysis.

The most plausible explanatory factor driving deficit rhetoric is the political incentive to externalize fiscal blame on the opposing party. Minority parties, while lacking any real legislative, governing, or subpoena power, have the capacity to frame the opposing party as fiscally irresponsible in hopes of improving their popularity or electoral prospects. This political incentive weakens once a party gains legislative control as it no longer becomes politically advantageous to discuss—or in this case, tweet—about the federal deficit.

Such an explanation is consistent with Kent Weaver's political theory of blame avoidance. Given that voters are more sensitive to negative outcomes than positive ones (negativity bias), Weaver observes that politicians are motivated to be 'blame minimizers', not 'credit maximizers'. Under Weaver's framework, governing parties would therefore have an incentive to suppress deficit rhetoric to minimize the visibility of a loss-allocating topic (the national debt). He also highlights a key distinction between governing powers: while majority parties can legislate and initiate policy, the opposition party has one key source of power—blame generation.

Consider this framework applied to the Republican party. From 2017–2021, Republicans had mostly majority legislative control. During this period, there was little political incentive to emphasize the national debt. However, once they no longer had legislative power (2021–2023), their political incentives reversed, motivating them to externalize fiscal blame to the Democratic party. Through this lens, one can view deficit rhetoric not as a proxy for fiscal concern, but as a political tool that is used when political parties no longer have power through traditional congressional means.

Another plausible explanation for these trends is offered by Justin Grimmer, Professor of Political Science at Stanford, who argues that public messaging (e.g., tweeting) is used to signal ideology that benefits politicians' electoral positioning. This framework could explain why members emphasize the deficit more: politicians want to signal to voters that they are fiscally responsible. If, for example, Republican voters value fiscal responsibility, Republican politicians would be motivated to emphasize the deficit to signal their hawkish ideology and improve electoral positioning.

Grimmer also makes an important distinction between public communication and voting patterns: what legislators say publicly is not the same as how they vote. Representatives may tweet about the deficit for electoral and ideological reasons but also vote in favor of deficit spending due to political constraints (party leadership, coalition requirements, etc.). This distinction helps explain how some congressional members have historically supported fiscal stimulus while also having relatively high deficit tweeting rates.

6.5 Implications for Voters, Media, and Interpretation of Rhetoric

Voters make decisions based on their interpretation of candidates' policy and governing intentions. These interpretations are partly constructed through the information voters consume, whether that be through speeches, interviews, or social media posts. However, in the case of the federal deficit, political messaging (for the most part) is not a reflection of genuine fiscal concern, but is instead a reflection of institutional positioning and political incentives. My research suggests that an uptick in a representative's deficit rhetoric will more often than not reflect a change in political contexts (power status, legislative timing) rather than a sincere change in policy perspective. Voters should therefore be aware of the current political atmosphere when drawing conclusions about a representative or candidate's opinions on the national debt.

The media plays an outsized role in forming current and future political environments, making it imperative for journalists to understand the relationship between deficit rhetoric and political incentives so as to maximize the objectivity and fairness of their political coverage. When covering a political party or representative's opinions regarding the national debt, media coverage should be aware of previous trends and current political contexts so as to appropriately contextualize the situation. The same applies to any stakeholders—researchers, forecasters, and political strategists—whose decisions are based upon the messaging of representatives and political parties more broadly. This research provides a solid foundation for all such stakeholders when making decisions on how to interpret political discourse surrounding the national debt.

6.6 Directions for Future Research

My research, while comprehensive in many respects, is solely focused on deficit tweeting rates among U.S. congressional members from 2017–2023. This leaves many avenues for supplemental research. Most notably, future research could examine whether the trends identified here extend beyond Twitter, whether that be to other social media platforms or to other communication channels entirely, including floor speeches, press releases, fundraising emails, or televised appearances. Moreover, it would be informative to perform similar analysis from either a more recent or larger timeframe—giving one greater insight into how parties, political leaders, and rank-and-file members change their messaging across fiscal and political contexts including the 2024 election and the passage of the One Big Beautiful Bill (2025).

A second consideration would be to analyze the degree of engagement (likes, retweets, views etc). One could examine whether engagement interacts with political contexts (power status, legislative periods etc). Such analysis would help illuminate the degree to which political incentives shape deficit rhetoric. For instance, there may be an additional political incentive for representatives to engage in such tweeting when it benefits their engagement levels systematically.

7 Conclusion

This paper provides the first large-scale empirical analysis of how politicians—in this case, U.S. congressional members—communicate about the federal deficit on social media. By layering Twitter data with other relevant political, macroeconomic and fiscal circumstances, I find that deficit rhetoric is driven far more by exogenous political contexts than by fiscal reality: tweeting rates are uncorrelated with the fiscal magnitude of legislation, but vary significantly with party affiliation, legislative timing, and institutional power. Notably, these effects (i.e., the sensitivity of members' tweeting rates to changes in political circumstances) are highly asymmetric across parties: Republicans increase deficit-related messaging five-fold when moving from in-power to out-of-power contexts, while Democrats' rates are largely unchanged between scenarios. At the leadership level, these dynamics are even more pronounced: Republican leaders (e.g., Mitch McConnell and Paul Ryan) are more responsive to shifts in political contexts and more closely track broader trends within their party.

The disconnect between economic conditions and deficit rhetoric suggests that messaging around the national debt (for U.S. congressional leaders) functions less as a reflection of genuine fiscal concern and more as a vehicle for advancing political objectives. My results point to two primary incentive mechanisms driving these communication choices. First, politicians, especially in the opposition, have an incentive to increase deficit-related messaging in order to externalize blame on the governing party—which could derail unwanted legislative agendas and erode trust more broadly. Second, deficit rhetoric could serve as a tool for ideological signaling: politicians have reason to discuss the federal deficit in certain circumstances—regardless of their intentions to actually reduce the debt itself—to convey fiscal responsibility to voters, potentially improving their popularity or chances of re-election. Taken together, my findings can serve as a foundation for any future research on political rhetoric and incentive frameworks and can be utilized by voters, media, and forecasters when making decisions on how to view political discourse surrounding the national debt.

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Appendix

A1. Deficit Tweeting by Party and Government Period

Deficit Tweeting by Party and Government Period				
Date	**Gov Type**	**Party**	**Avg Def Tweets**	**Num of Tweets**
2017–2019	Unified Republicans	Democrat	0.9%	509,132
		Republican	0.3%	351,933
2019–2021	Divided Republicans	Democrat	0.4%	896,973
		Republican	0.5%	530,190
2021–2023	Unified Democrats	Democrat	0.7%	732,058
		Republican	1.4%	585,125

A2. Member-Level Deficit Tweeting

Top 15 Members by Total Deficit-Related Tweets (2017–2023)

Top 15 Members by Total Deficit-Related Tweets (2017–2023)

'In power' refers to when a member's party held the presidency.

Member	Total Tweets	Deficit Tweets	% Deficit Tweets	% In Power	% Out of Power	In–Out Difference
Chip Roy	44325	658	1.48%	1.75%	1.00%	–0.75%
Pramila Jayapal	34591	516	1.49%	2.63%	0.98%	–1.65%
Elizabeth Warren	18511	471	2.54%	4.91%	1.71%	–3.20%
Rick Scott	11577	382	3.30%	1.18%	5.96%	4.78%
Ro Khanna	30748	342	1.11%	1.28%	1.05%	–0.24%
Don Beyer	34649	316	0.91%	1.61%	0.61%	–1.00%
Chuck Schumer	13167	260	1.97%	4.00%	1.03%	–2.97%
Bernie Sanders	17104	258	1.51%	1.34%	1.54%	0.20%
Steny Hoyer	13340	247	1.85%	0.62%	2.24%	1.62%
Dwight Evans	35160	236	0.67%	0.79%	0.59%	–0.19%
Jason Smith	6104	230	3.77%	0.61%	8.95%	8.34%
Don Bacon	27855	223	0.80%	0.38%	1.24%	0.86%
Andy Biggs	21541	218	1.01%	1.04%	0.92%	–0.13%
Ilhan Omar	17077	217	1.27%	1.16%	1.33%	0.17%
Mike Braun	4151	213	5.13%	1.90%	7.70%	5.80%

Top 15 Members by Share of Tweets About the Deficit (Min. 500 Tweets)

Top 15 Members by Share of Tweets About the Deficit (Min. 500 Tweets)

'In power' refers to when a member's party held the presidency.

Member	Deficit Tweets	% Deficit Tweets	% Out of Power
Jay Obernolte	70	7.89%	7.93%
Randy Feenstra	128	6.08%	6.09%
Mike Braun	213	5.13%	7.70%
Mike Carey	61	4.85%	4.85%
Cynthia Lummis	141	4.50%	4.68%
Kevin Hern	109	4.48%	5.38%
Ben McAdams	51	3.92%	3.92%
Jason Smith	230	3.77%	8.95%
Rick Scott	382	3.30%	5.96%
Mitt Romney	83	3.25%	4.11%
Dave Brat	25	3.03%	0.00%
Louise Slaughter	19	3.01%	3.01%
Rand Paul	195	2.94%	2.35%
Mike Enzi	40	2.78%	0.00%
Jake LaTurner	41	2.73%	2.81%

Top 15 Members with Largest Shift in Deficit Tweeting (In vs. Out of Power)

Top 15 Members with Largest Shift in Deficit Tweeting (In vs. Out of Power)

'In power' refers to when a member's party held the presidency.

Member	% In Power	% Out of Power	In–Out Difference
Jason Smith	0.61%	8.95%	8.34%
Lloyd Smucker	0.66%	6.77%	6.11%
Mike Braun	1.90%	7.70%	5.80%
Rick Scott	1.18%	5.96%	4.78%
Mike Crapo	0.06%	4.42%	4.36%
John Rose	0.00%	3.96%	3.96%
Kevin Hern	1.57%	5.38%	3.81%
Patrick McHenry	0.35%	3.84%	3.49%
Doug LaMalfa	0.06%	3.55%	3.49%
Tim Scott	0.06%	3.49%	3.43%
Ben Cline	0.60%	3.95%	3.36%
Elizabeth Warren	4.91%	1.71%	–3.20%
Ron Johnson	0.51%	3.65%	3.14%
Alex Mooney	0.62%	3.69%	3.07%
Daniel Webster	0.29%	3.28%	3.00%

Bolded names indicate members who tweeted *less* about the deficit while in power.